

SENATE No. 457

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Bruce E. Tarr

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act to establish the Middle School Innovation Fund.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	
<i>Bruce E. Tarr</i>	<i>First Essex and Middlesex</i>	
<i>Michael O. Moore</i>	<i>Second Worcester</i>	<i>3/20/2025</i>
<i>Ann-Margaret Ferrante</i>	<i>5th Essex</i>	<i>3/27/2025</i>

SENATE No. 457

By Mr. Tarr, a petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 457) of Bruce E. Tarr for legislation to provide grants and other support to programs administered by local school districts that engage project-centered group learning methods in grades 5-8. Education.

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act to establish the Middle School Innovation Fund.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 Section 1 - There is hereby established and set up on the books of the commonwealth, the
2 Commonwealth Middle School Innovation Fund, the purpose of which shall be to provide grants
3 and other support to programs administered by local school districts that engage project-centered
4 group learning methods in grades 5-8 that integrate multiple areas of subject matter including but
5 not limited to science and mathematics, promote learning among students at various skill levels,
6 and seek to comport with the requirements of time on learning as contained in statute and
7 regulations promulgated by the department of elementary and secondary education, including but
8 not limited to 603 CMR 27.00.

9 Such grants may be used for purposes including but not limited to personnel costs,
10 curriculum development and design, and materials.

11 Section 2 - Amounts shall be credited to the fund from legislative appropriation, gifts,
12 grants, and other sources, provided that the department of elementary and secondary education

shall work to identify and secure such grants to the maximum feasible extent. Amounts contained in the fund shall not revert to the general fund, but shall remain available for expenditure by the department, which shall promulgate regulations to distribute such grants in a fair and equitable manner. In doing so the department shall consider factors including but not limited to geographic distribution, distribution across the range of sizes of local school districts across the commonwealth, and maximizing the impact of such grants in developing programs and curriculum that are replicable and sustainable for such districts.

Section 3 - The fund shall be administered by the department, which shall develop and maintain the Commonwealth Middle School Innovation Council for the purposes of advising the department for the purposes of maximizing the effectiveness, sustainability, and practicality of programs funded in whole or in part by such grants. Said council shall be chaired by the commissioner of the department, and shall also include the secretary of education and the secretary of energy and economic development, and 9 additional members to be appointed by the governor, 1 of whom shall represent the Massachusetts Association of School Committees, 1 of whom shall represent the Massachusetts Association of School Superintendents, 3 of whom shall represent middle school educators from diverse geographic regions in the commonwealth, 1 of whom shall represent local charitable education foundations, 2 of whom shall represent parents of middle school students in the commonwealth, 1 of whom shall represent an organized labor organization representing educators in the commonwealth, and 1 of whom shall represent an institution of higher learning in the commonwealth with expertise in education and science, mathematics, and engineering. The council shall meet not less than twice per calendar year, provided that its meetings shall be public and shall provide for remote observation by the public through electronic means.

36 Section 4 - The department shall produce an annual report detailing the amounts and
37 recipients of grants pursuant to this section, any innovative programs developed or supported by
38 such grants, opportunities for replication of such programs, and any legislative or regulatory
39 recommendations to improve or support the work of the fund. Said report shall be filed with the
40 clerks of the House and Senate, whom shall post them electronically for public inspection, not
41 later than December 31 of each calendar year.